

THE LONE WOMAN OF SAN NICOLAS.

By a Special Contributor.

ABOUT eighty miles to the southwest of Santa Catalina lies the island of San Nicolas. Its shores are wind-swept and forbidding; it has neither trees nor shrubs on its entire area, and its surface is largely composed of loose and shifting sands. The island is a tableland, 500 or 600 feet high, about nine miles long, with an average of four miles in width. On top the island is almost as bare as a floor, cut into here and there by jagged cañons.

However desolate it may appear, San Nicolas has not always been as we now find it. Evidences are not wanting to show that at one time it contained forests of trees, and was densely populated. Large stumps of trees are occasionally found, and the early navigators, who have left a record of their visits to this island, speak of trees, bushes and moss. There is also testimony in the great quantities of land-shells which are found there that there must have been a luxurious vegetation. That it was densely populated is evidenced by the immense mounds of seashells, principally abalone, which are found on the tableland of the interior. One row or rick of these, which at the present day stands as high as a man's head and almost a mile in length, must have required centuries to form.

But little is known of the character of the early inhabitants, although there are persons still living who saw the last remnant of the race of Indians who formerly inhabited the island, in the person of "The Lone Woman of San Nicolas," as she was called. Dr. Stephen Bowers had the story of this woman, who was the sole inhabitant of the island for eighteen years, di-

enter the Golden Gate. Afterward, there being no craft larger than Indian canoes on this portion of the coast, no effort was made to rescue the woman, and the fact of her being left alone gradually passed out of mind.

In 1851, Capt. John Nidever of Santa Barbara sailed to the island, hunting for sea otter, and was surprised to find human tracks and other evidences of life, but a heavy wind coming up, he was obliged to return to his vessel, and as the storm continued for several days, he left the island without having pursued his investigations.

The next winter, in 1852, Capt. Nidever again visited the island, and found in the crotch of a small tree a basket. Removing the sealskin covering, he discovered a sort of gown made of bird skins, a silver pipe, bow, needles, abalone fish-hooks, etc. Capt. Nidever and his men sought the owner for several days, but failed to find her, and a strong southwest wind coming up, they with difficulty got away and sailed for San Miguel Island.

In July, 1853, Capt. Nidever again sailed to San Nicolas with the avowed purpose of finding the lone woman. His crew consisted of Charles Brown, an Irishman, and four Mission Indians. For several days the search was kept up, and the woman was finally found in a little wickiup, or circular inclosure made of brush, situated toward the center of the island. When the men came upon her she was removing the blubber from a seal. She arose with dignity, saluting the strangers with a smile. She was dressed in a gown made of bird skins. It was cut low in the neck, and reached to the ankles. Her hair was a yellowish brown, probably caused in part from exposure, and she appeared to be about 60 years old. After roasting some nuts for her guests, of which they partook with a relish, they made signs for her to accompany them to the vessel, which she did without hesitation.

The party remained on the island for a month, the woman making herself useful in bringing wood and water. She gave evidences of having seen much suffering during the eighteen years of her isolation, but she was very cheerful, and remained so until the last.

On reaching Santa Barbara, the rescued castaway became an object of great interest to all the country around, and many persons visited her. Three of the Mission fathers—Gonzales, Sanchez and Jimeno—came to see her, and although they were acquainted with many dialects, yet they could not understand hers, nor could she understand them. Indians were brought from Santa Ynez, Los Angeles and other places, but none were able to converse with her. It is probable that she had entirely forgotten her own dialect, and during the eighteen weary years of her solitude had constructed another, known only to herself. She soon became quite adept in conversing by signs, and gave Capt. Nidever to understand that when she went back for her child she found that it had been killed and devoured by dogs. She had sometimes seen ships sailing past the island, but none ever came to rescue her.

Everything was an object of curiosity to her. A yoke of oxen drawing an old Spanish cart greatly excited her. Seeing a man on horseback, she thought the horse and rider one; and seeing him alight, her amazement was great. She came and sat beside him, felt his clothing, and seemed to look upon him as a supernatural being.

The food of civilization, of which she partook to excess, did not agree with her, and she died about four weeks after landing at Santa Barbara, or two months after her rescue. After her death, her gown of bird skins, and various trinkets, were sent to Rome, where they may probably still be seen among the curiosities of the Vatican.

San Nicolas has proven to be a veritable treasure field for the archæologist and relic hunter. Tons of relics of the aboriginal inhabitants have been unearthed and carried away—and still the work goes on, although under increasing difficulties. Frequent parties may be found on the island, excavating the loose sands and digging into the mounds in search of relics left by the early inhabitants during the stone age.

It was a custom with the Indians at the death of one of their tribe to bury with him, for ready use in the happy hunting grounds, all his treasures and effects. Hence it is necessary to find their burial places in order to find their treasures. The burial places were nearly always in the vicinity of the water, and the skeletons were found invariably interred in a sitting posture, with the arms clasped about the knees. Most of the graves on the island have been despoiled by the relic hunter, but patient search continues to bring to light many curious objects.

The fact that the Indians of San Nicolas buried their dead in coffins is made the basis for the claim that they attained to a higher state of civilization than those of the other islands or of the mainland, as no other tribes have been known to use coffins. It appears also that caste was observed among them, for not all were thus buried. In digging over a small space four coffins were found, while in a tract immediately adjoining were exhumed a number of skeletons which were not only coffinless, but in a very imperfect state of preservation. All were broken and fragmentary, showing that the owners were poor and of little worth in the social scale. On the other hand, the coffins frequently yielded a rich harvest, and the articles were almost invariably perfect. The coffins were neatly constructed of plank, from an inch to an inch and a half thick, and from what source it was derived furnishes another opportunity for conjecture. They were cemented together, made water-proof and air-tight with asphaltum, and usually measured about two feet square and four feet long. They contained, with one exception, a single skeleton each. The exception contained three. One of the skulls was enormous one, measuring twenty-two inches in girth, with an extraordinary high forehead and cranial development, indicating a high order of intellect. The other two were much smaller, giving occasion for the belief that it might have been a chief and his two wives.

That he was a chief of importance is shown from the fact that a fine pestle taken from this coffin was found to be inlaid with a shell in the handle. When opened the hair on one of the skulls was apparently in a perfect state of preservation, but as soon as the air was admitted it fell into impalpable powder, while the

odor was overpowering, it was two days before the contents of the coffin could be examined.

Invariably the relic hunter came to know when he was coming upon a coffin, for he always found the skeleton of a dog, with a fish-hook or ear-ring, buried about eighteen inches above the coffin. What this meant can only be surmised, but apparently it was a sign of royalty, high station or wealth. It seems evident, from appearances, that the bodies were not placed in the coffins immediately after death, but were left to decay, to some extent at least, for it was impossible that the three bodies could have been placed in so small a space. The graves containing coffins were also marked with headstones, or monuments of whalebone, usually monstrous ribs or large sections of the vertebrae, being used.

The treasure boxes found in the coffins are most interesting. They consist of two abalone shells, one inverted over the other, and the two plastered tightly together with asphaltum. Those opened contained pearls, ear-rings, fish-hooks, whistles, bracelets, wampum, etc. The usual place for finding wampum is in the mouth of the cadaver.

Many of the skulls when found are encased in shells, deftly placed all over and about them. One skull taken out had a wicker basket turned over it, which some solicitous friend thought to preserve to the owner in the spirit world, by pouring asphaltum into it and clapping it on the head. They expected to put asphaltum on the outside, however, and when found the only traces of the basket were the marks in the asphaltum.

The shell mounds are objects of great curiosity. They are found in all parts of the island, and are the more numerous as the interior is reached, where, though miles from the water's edge, the whole surface of the ground is seemingly covered with shells, presenting a picture of unparalleled gorgeousness in the sunlight, every prismatic point giving off reflections as brilliant as that of myriads of diamonds. Many of these shells are yet whole, and of extraordinary size. The coloring is exquisite, the garnishes having been softened by age, as many of them no doubt are centuries old.

The island has but one human inhabitant, the lone shepherd of San Nicolas. His is not an enviable lot, although he seems to enjoy his isolation and his company. A few sheep are kept on the island, though in the absence of bushes or grass one wonders how they exist. Their principal food is a thick, waxy "ice" plant, which grows out of the sand at the eastern end of the island.

The old Chinese hut at the western end of the island, a stone building put up by Chinese fishermen many years ago, aptly illustrates the general character of the weather of San Nicolas. Few visitors return without a story of the fierce winds which assail them at most unexpected times. The hut, about 15x30 feet in

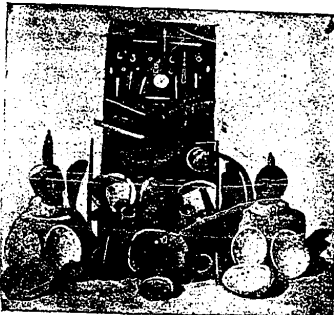


THE LONE SHEPHERDER.

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The Russians in the early days made occasional visits to San Nicolas Island in quest of the fur of the sea otter. They brought with them natives from Alaska, who were left on the island to continue the work of capturing otter, while they returned to the north. While the Russians were absent, these Alaska Indians, having been taught the use of firearms, rose up and took possession of the women of the island, and in the conflict which followed killed all the men and male children. When the Russian ships came again, they took away the Alaskans, and the women were abandoned to their fate. This was some time previous to the year 1835. In some way the news of this massacre reached the Mission fathers on the mainland, and they dispatched the schooner Peor as Naha to the island to bring away the remaining inhabitants. The vessel sailed about the first of August, 1835.

After the Indian women were ready for embarkation, one of them made signs that her child had been left behind, and she was permitted to go in search of it. While she was absent a strong wind arose, which threatened the security of the schooner, and they were compelled to set sail and leave the unfortunate woman and her child behind. The schooner ran before the wind to San Pedro, where the Indians were landed, some being taken to Los Angeles and others to San Gabriel Mission. The vessel, which was owned in Monterey, went north, and was wrecked in the attempt to



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size, and built with heavy walls of stone, originally on the level surface, has now the appearance of a Kansas dug-out. The winds have heaped the sands about it until only the roof is visible above the surrounding level. This, with the exception of the lone shepherd's shack, is the only building now on the island.

The disappearance of the forests and shrubbery is unaccountable, and although our party made diligent search for some remains of the wickiup where the lone woman was found, and also for a cave which she is said to have inhabited, they found no signs of either.

There are many things of interest about the island, principal among which is the bird and seal life. Innumerable shag, seeming to reach into the hundreds of thousands, make their home here, and roost at night on a low reef, the birds covering the face of the rock for a mile or more. It is most interesting to see them start out in the morning on their quest for food. They fly in Indian file, forming a string of birds many miles long, and returning in the same order in the evening. A large colony of seals also has its home here, and one day nothing but a commotion in the water, the exploring party discovered a school of yellowtail, driving another school of sardines ashore. Hooks and lines were brought out, and the stranded sardines being utilized for bait, the fun began. It was fast and furious. In the space of one hour the three men had seventy-seven yellowtail heaped up on the beach.

The surf on occasions is tremendous, the waves rolling in thirty feet high, and coming over to fall with the report of a cannon, fairly shaking the earth.

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However desolate it may appear, San Nicolas has not always been as we now find it. Evidences are not wanting to show that at one time it contained forests of trees, and was densely populated. Large stumps of trees are occasionally found, and the early navigators, who have left a record of their visits to this island, speak of trees, bushes and moss. There is also testimony in the great quantities of land-shells which are found there that there must have been a luxurious vegetation. That it was densely populated is evidenced by the immense mounds of seashells, principally abalone, which are found on the tableland of the interior. One row or rick of these, which at the present day stands as high as a man's head and almost a mile in length, must have required centuries to form.

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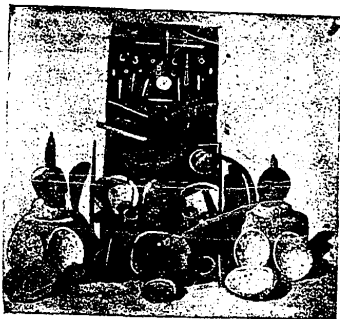
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